

A Sermon Against the Unbarred Door

Attend, you who dwell beneath stone, and you who sleep beneath thin roofs.

The heart is a fortress, but no wall is righteous merely because it is high. Vharencrag Fortress stands in the High Spires, founded in 84 AS, severe among the mountainous crags. Its garrison is 9,478, and still it remains contested. Let no keeper of gates boast that numbers are holiness. Let no Warden-Commander mistake command for purity.

For there is one among the wardens whose name is spoken with a wound in the mouth: Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless is a major Warden-Commander, born in 258 AS. The years have given him authority, and secrecy has given that authority a shadow. He projects command undermined by secrecy; wherever his word is heard, distrust follows like a second cloak. The oathless guardian may still carry the key. He may still know which gate is weak. He may still stand before the enemy and call himself shield.

But Ignatz secretly sells intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel.

Hear this plainly, lest the tongue of fear soften it. A secret bargain is still a bargain. A stolen truth is still a weapon. The hand that feeds the enemy need not draw a sword to open a wound.

Yet do not think the danger sleeps only in council chambers.

When the lamps fail and the mind loosens its grip, the Thorn Wraith comes. It is a dream-feeder, drawing its nature from the invasion and consumption of dreams. Its ghostly form is threaded with thorn-like shapes, its outline cruel and insubstantial. It belongs as much to the terror of sleep as to the waking world. It does not batter the door. It waits within the hush, intimate and predatory, patient as hunger.

Therefore guard the inward gate. Distrust the voice that asks for surrender in exchange for comfort. Distrust the guardian who demands trust while concealing his trade. Distrust also the dream that tells you no enemy can enter because your walls are old.

Vharencrag Fortress was founded in 84 AS. Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless was born in 258 AS. The Thorn Wraith has no need of a birth-year to find the sleeping. These truths stand apart, yet they teach one lesson: stone, office, and waking courage are not enough.

Keep watch. Hold fast. Let no oath be empty, and let no silence be mistaken for safety.